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Ministry Resources Hub

Joshua Nations

Lesson 8. Prayer

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I. INTRODUCTION: THE CENTRALITY OF PRAYER

A. Why Prayer is Foundational:

1. Prayer is the lifeblood of every disciple. It connects us to God, aligns us with His will, empowers our ministry, and opens the doors for transformation in the lives of others. Throughout Scripture, prayer is shown as the key to intimacy with God, the fuel for mission, and the power behind every spiritual breakthrough.
2. **Jesus Modeled a Life of Prayer:** Jesus, our greatest example of disciple-making, prioritized prayer. He spent time in prayer before major decisions (Luke 6:12), after intense ministry (Mark 1:35), and during pivotal moments in His life (Matthew 26:36-44). Jesus taught His disciples to pray (Luke 11:1-4) and expected prayer to be the foundation of their lives and ministries.

II. THE POWER OF PRAYER IN DISCIPLE-MAKING MOVEMENTS

- A. **Prayer Precedes Breakthrough:** In DMM, prayer is often the first step in entering new areas, seeking divine guidance, and preparing hearts to receive the Gospel. Movements that grow rapidly and multiply are always rooted in a culture of deep, sustained prayer.
- B. **Partnering with God in His Mission:** Prayer aligns our hearts with God's mission. As we pray, we partner with Him to bring His Kingdom to earth. Prayer is not just about asking for things; it is about listening, discerning God's will, and acting in obedience to what He reveals.

III. THE BIBLICAL FOUNDATIONS OF PRAYER

A. Jesus' Teaching on Prayer:

1. **The Lord's Prayer (Matthew 6:9-13):** Jesus gave His disciples a model for prayer that touches on key areas: honoring God, seeking His will, asking for provision, confessing sins, and seeking protection from evil. This prayer guides believers in approaching God with both reverence and dependence.
2. **Persistent Prayer (Luke 18:1-8):** Jesus taught the parable of the persistent widow to encourage His disciples to pray continually and not lose heart.

Persistent prayer is essential in DMMs, where we often need to intercede for long periods before seeing breakthroughs in people's lives or communities.

B. The Apostles and Prayer:

1. **The Early Church's Prayer Life:** The early church was deeply committed to prayer. In Acts 2:42, it says they devoted themselves "to the apostles' teaching and to fellowship, to the breaking of bread and to prayer." Prayer was at the center of the church's life, and it fueled their growth and mission.
2. **Praying for Boldness (Acts 4:23-31):** When the early church faced opposition, they didn't pray for safety; they prayed for boldness. In response, God shook the place where they were praying and filled them with the Holy Spirit. This empowered them to speak the word of God boldly. Boldness in prayer leads to boldness in mission.

C. Paul's Teachings on Prayer:

1. **Pray Without Ceasing (1 Thessalonians 5:17):** Paul instructs believers to "pray without ceasing," emphasizing that prayer is not a one-time event but a continual, ongoing conversation with God.
2. **Intercessory Prayer (Colossians 4:2-4):** Paul urges believers to be devoted to prayer, to stay watchful, and to pray for open doors for the Gospel. Intercessory prayer for others—whether for individuals or for entire communities—is a powerful way to partner with God's mission.

IV. TYPES OF PRAYER IN DISCIPLE'S LIFE

A. Adoration and Worship

1. **Focusing on Who God Is:** Before anything else, prayer should begin with adoration—acknowledging who God is and worshiping Him for His greatness, faithfulness, and love. This aligns our hearts with Him and reminds us of His sovereignty over our lives and mission.
2. **Practical Application:** Start every prayer session by spending time in worship, whether through song, Scripture, or spoken words of praise. This sets the right tone and focuses the group on God's power and goodness.

B. Listening Prayer

1. **Hearing God's Voice:** Listening prayer is an important practice where we not only speak to God but also listen for His voice. This is key in discerning His will for our ministry, receiving direction for our personal lives, and hearing His heart for those we are discipling.
2. **Practical Application:** After praying or reading Scripture, pause in silence and ask God to speak. Encourage group members to share any impressions, scriptures, or words they feel God is placing on their hearts. This can also be a powerful way to discern God's guidance in outreach or evangelism efforts.

C. Intercessory Prayer

1. **Standing in the Gap:** Intercessory prayer involves praying on behalf of others—whether it's for individuals, families, or entire communities. In DMMs, intercession is often focused on praying for the lost, asking God to soften hearts and prepare the way for the Gospel.
2. **Practical Application:** Make a list of people or groups you are reaching out to or planning to engage with. Regularly intercede for these individuals and communities, asking God to open doors for the Gospel, bring conviction of sin, and reveal His love to them.

D. Prayers of Repentance

1. **Confession and Cleansing:** Repentance is a key aspect of prayer that aligns us with God's holiness. Confession of sin removes the barriers that prevent us from experiencing intimacy with God and effectiveness in ministry.
2. **Practical Application:** Encourage regular times of personal and group repentance. This could be part of the "Look Back" section of a 3/3 Group meeting or a time of reflection during prayer walks. Confess personal and corporate sins, asking for forgiveness and renewal.

E. Spiritual Warfare Prayer

1. **Engaging in Battle:** In disciple-making movements, there will often be spiritual opposition as the enemy seeks to prevent the advancement of God's Kingdom. Spiritual warfare prayer is about taking authority over demonic forces, praying for protection, and standing firm in Christ's victory.
2. **Practical Application:** When entering new areas for ministry, engage in spiritual warfare prayer, asking God to bind the forces of darkness and release people

from spiritual blindness. Pray for protection for team members and those you are discipling.

F. Prayers for Boldness and Open Doors

1. **Praying for Courage:** Just as the early disciples prayed for boldness, we too must ask God for courage to share the Gospel, even in difficult or hostile environments. Boldness in prayer leads to boldness in evangelism.
2. **Praying for Open Doors:** Ask God to open doors for ministry and prepare the hearts of those you will encounter.
3. **Practical Application:** At the end of each group meeting, ask participants to pray specifically for open doors to share their testimony or the Gospel with others during the week.

V. EQUIPPING DISCIPLES WITH THE LORD'S PRAYER

A. The Lord's Prayer Frame

1. The Prayer Frame uses the Lord's Prayer (Matthew 6:9-13) as a model for structuring prayer. This frame helps maintain a full prayer life, ensuring that different aspects of our relationship with God are addressed.
2. **Why Use a Framework?:** The goal is to have a holistic approach to prayer, incorporating worship, intercession, confession, and surrender.

B. The Six Elements of the Prayer Frame

1. **Palm = Relationship:** As the palm is the foundation for our fingers and thumb, time alone with God is the foundation for our personal relationship with Him. (Matthew 6:6) We acknowledge that relationship – "Our Father in heaven. . . ." (Matthew 6:9)
2. **Thumb = Worship:** Our thumb reminds us that we must worship God before we ask for anything – ". . . hallowed be Your name." (Matthew 6:9)
3. **First Finger = Surrender:** Next we surrender our lives, plans, family, finances, work, future – everything — "Your kingdom come, Your will be done. . . ." (Matthew 6:10)
4. **Middle Finger = Ask:** Then we ask God to meet our needs, small and large – "Give us this day our daily bread." (Matthew 6:11)

5. **Fourth Finger = Forgive:** Now we ask God to forgive our sins, and we must forgive others – “Forgive us as we forgive others.” (Matthew 6:12)
6. **Little Finger = Protection:** We seek protection. “Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil.” (Matthew 6:13) Pray for strength to overcome temptation.
7. **Returning to Worship (Thumb Again):** As reflected in the Psalms, we end just as we began – we worship Almighty God – “ Yours is the kingdom and the power and the glory forever. Amen” (Matthew 6:13).

C. Practical Implementation of the Lord’s Prayer

1. **Daily Practice:** Encourage participants to set aside 15 minutes each day to pray through each part of the framework.
2. **Small Group Practice:** During meetings, take turns leading different parts of the frame, allowing each member to practice and grow in praying out loud.

VI. THE PRAYER CYCLE

- A. This is a guided pattern for spending an hour in prayer. It is helpful to enable people to understand various aspects of prayer and to increase their capacity for prayer. The intention is to spend five minutes on each segment.
 1. **Praise:** Start your prayer hour by praising the Lord. Praise Him for things that are on your mind right now. Praise Him for one special thing He has done in your life in the past week. Praise Him for His goodness to your family.
 2. **Wait:** Spend this time waiting on the Lord. Be silent and let Him pull together reflections for you.

3. **Confess:** Ask the Holy Spirit to show you anything in your life that might be displeasing to Him. Ask Him to point out attitudes that are wrong, as well as specific acts for which you have not yet made a prayer of confession. Now confess that to the Lord so that you might be cleansed.
4. **Read the Word:** Spend time reading in the Psalms, in the prophets, and passages on prayer located in the New Testament.
5. **Ask:** Make general requests on behalf of yourself and others.
6. **Intercession:** Make specific requests on behalf of yourself and others.
7. **Pray the Word:** Pray specific passages. Scriptural prayers as well as a number of psalms lend themselves well to this purpose.
8. **Thank:** Give thanks to the Lord for the things in your life, on behalf of your family, and on behalf of your church.
9. **Sing:** Sing songs of praise or worship or a hymn or spiritual song.
0. **Meditate:** Ask the Lord to speak to you. Have a pen and paper ready to record the impressions He gives you.
1. **Listen:** Spend time merging the things you have read, things you have prayed and things you have sung and see how the Lord brings them all together to speak to you.
2. **Praise:** Praise the Lord for the time you have had to spend with Him and the impressions He has given you. Praise Him for His glorious attributes.

B. Exercises for the Prayer Cycle

1. **Journaling:** Keep a journal where you write down thoughts and reflections during each part of the cycle. This helps track growth and recognize answered prayers.
 2. **Prayer Partners:** Pair members to meet once a week to practice praying through the cycle together. This helps build confidence in prayer.
 3. **PRACTICE:** Spend an hour praying through the Prayer Cycle.
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This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).